

LOVE IS BLIND



Naya is my best friend. Naya is a corruption of her native Igbo name which I found difficult to pronounce. She laughed each time I called her full Igbo name and said that my pronunciation took the meaning out of the name, so I stuck with Naya. Naya is petite, and her skin color is the rich earthy tone of the loamy soil. Her teeth is coconut white and evenly shaped. People often told her she could model for a toothpaste company.

I can't remember how we became best of friends over ten years ago, but I remember that we were in our penultimate year in secondary school, and we were in the same class. Everyone seemed to have an issue with Naya. She was

distrustful and defensive. She believed everyone underestimated her, and people were out to take advantage of her. It was not rare to see her raising her voice or quarelling with someone. I found her interesting in a curious way, and I decided that I would be her friend.

A “hello” there, and a “how are you today” here, began the process of our inseparable bonding. We went everywhere together, our hands locked, and students staring at us. I can still remember that the first voice recorder I ever saw was her own. She had sophisticated machines like that. She would record lectures, and have me record lecture notes for her. She studied by playing the recorded tapes. Naya also had a typewriter in school. She was the only student that had one, and was permitted to hand in her assignments typed, instead of written like the rest of us. She also typed her examination answers right there in the exam hall. Yes, Naya was that girl that stood out.

Today, as Naya sat on the cream and coffee coloured sofa in the sitting room of my two bedroom apartment, eating the noodles and egg that she insisted I make for her, it dawned on me that I have never visited her house. This is the second time she has travelled across states to visit me. I made a silent vow to return her visit.

We recounted our years and memories in our secondary school, and I summoned the courage to ask her the question I had wanted to ask the first time we ever spoke. I never asked her, even after we became best of friends, because though I was curious, I wanted her to know that she was just like any other person, regardless.

“Naya, what happened to your eyes?”, I blurted.

She turned her face to me. I stared at those eyes, set deep in her face. The dark pupils stared back at me, without seeing me, or anything else. Her eyelids

blinked in quick succession, just like I remembered them. Her bushy brows furrowed, but her perfect teeth were bared in amusement. She threw her head back and let out a low chuckle.

“Why haven’t you asked me this question all these years. I have been expecting it”, she said.

“Well..., I don’t know. I guess I was waiting for you to erm, open up if you erm, wanted to”, I stammered.

“Open up *kwa? Odiegwu*. Maybe that’s why we became so close. It didn’t come up as an issue”, she replied. “I had chicken pox when I was eight years old. It was not properly treated”, she responded flatly.

Her answer housed regrets and wishes. I placed my hand on her shoulder and gave her a small squeeze, the type I usually gave her whenever she wanted to lose her temper in school. I had so many questions to ask her.

I wanted to know how long she learned to use the typewriter before going to a regular school. I wanted to find out the images she had in her mind when she would ask me to describe the weather and sky to her as we locked hands and walked from the school hostel to the classroom. I wanted to understand how she could move about, and travel without a cane. I was curious about what she saw in dreams. I had so many questions, but I just held her shoulder.

I looked at her face again, and her eyes were shut as if she was recalling what it was like, before the darkness enveloped her world, forever.

It was the most intimate moment of our years, save for that day in the hostel when she requested to feel my face, so she could “see” what I looked like. She told me I was beautiful, and that has been the most valid compliment I

received in my life because it was not based on any created standard. It was a compliment of not just a face, but a heart, from a grateful heart.

I tried to dispel the tense atmosphere by talking about the harsh economy, and how life was treating everyone unfairly and how I was only just managing to get by. Then she said something that I will frame and hang on the wall of my bedroom. She said, “You can do anything, you can see. Stop complaining”.

“Ehen, what is that your Igbo name again. Naya has taken over it”, I asked when I was seeing her off.

“So that you will pronounce the meaning out of it, abi?”, she quipped. “Ifunanya”, she replied and laughed.

“What does it mean in English anyway?” I queried.

“Love”. “Ifunanya means Love”, she responded.

*LOVE IS ******



THE END

CATEGORY: CREATIVE NON-FICTION